

The Acadiana Home Buyer's & Seller's Guide

Carrie Billeaud, Realtor · eXp Realty

Six things Louisiana does differently — flood zones, the homestead exemption, notary closings, zero-down USDA loans, seller disclosures, and how the towns around Lafayette compare — compiled into one guide, with sources.

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Informational only **NOT LEGAL, TAX, LENDING OR INSURANCE ADVICE**

This guide compiles publicly available information in plain language for people buying or selling a home in the Acadiana area. It is not legal, tax, lending or insurance advice, and it is not a substitute for guidance from a licensed attorney, notary, lender, insurance agent, or tax professional. Laws, maps, program rules and market figures change. Verify anything that matters to your decision with the relevant professional before you rely on it. Sources are linked inline throughout.

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PART 1

Flood Zones & Flood Insurance in Lafayette Parish

Before you fall in love with a house, find out what flood zone it's in — it affects whether flood insurance is required, what it costs, and what your real risk looks like. FEMA defines a Special Flood Hazard Area (SFHA) as an area that would be inundated by the flood event with a 1% chance of being equaled or exceeded in any given year — the "base flood" or "100-year flood" ([FEMA](#)).

Zone A

High-risk — at least a 1% annual chance of flooding. Flood insurance is mandatory with a federally backed mortgage ([FloodSmart.gov](#)).

Zone AE

High-risk with a mapped base flood elevation. Same 1% annual chance and same mandatory insurance requirement for federally backed mortgages ([FloodSmart.gov](#)).

Zone X (shaded)

Moderate flood hazard — usually the area between the 100-year and 500-year flood limits ([FloodSmart.gov](#)).

Zone X (unshaded)

Minimal flood hazard — outside the SFHA and above the 0.2%-annual-chance (500-year) flood level ([FEMA](#)).

"Low risk" isn't "no risk" WORTH KNOWING

Zone X sits outside the SFHA, but low flood risk does not mean zero flood risk ([Neptune Flood](#)). Nationally, more than 1 in 3 NFIP flood insurance claims come from properties in moderate- to low-risk zones ([FloodSmart.gov](#)). The August 2016 Louisiana flood — a National Weather Service–characterized less-than-1-in-1,000-year rainfall event — damaged roughly 146,000 homes statewide, and most affected homeowners lacked flood insurance ([Wikipedia](#), citing NWS/NOAA data).

When it's required, and how to check an address

Flood insurance is mandatory for homes in high-risk zones (A and AE) that carry a mortgage from a federally regulated or government-backed lender ([FEMA](#); [Louisiana Dept. of Insurance](#)). Outside those zones it's optional — but worth pricing out (confirm the requirement for your loan with your lender). Flood zone lines can split a single street, so check the specific address on official sources: FEMA's Flood Map Service Center ([msc.fema.gov](#)), the LSU AgCenter FloodMaps portal ([maps.lsuagcenter.com/floodmaps](#)), or Lafayette Consolidated Government's flood maps page ([lafayettela.gov](#)).

What it costs

FEMA fully implemented Risk Rating 2.0 as of April 1, 2023, pricing a property by distance to water, flood frequency, flood type, elevation and rebuild cost rather than zone alone ([FEMA](#)). About 80% of Louisiana NFIP policyholders saw premiums increase under the new model ([Chabert Insurance](#)).

\$350–\$743

Typical Lafayette-area annual premium

(Chabert Insurance)

~\$569

Zone X LA average / year

(Chabert Insurance)

~\$850–\$1,400

Zone AE LA average / year

(Chabert Insurance)

30 days

Standard NFIP waiting period before coverage begins

Ways to lower the cost CONFIRM WITH A PROFESSIONAL

Private flood insurance is often 20–40% cheaper than NFIP for homes in Zone X or a lower-risk part of Zone AE with good elevation, and an elevation certificate can be used to adjust NFIP premiums downward ([Chabert Insurance](#)). Ask a licensed flood insurance agent whether either applies to a specific property. Because NFIP carries a 30-day waiting period, arrange coverage well before closing — not the week of.

Parish-specific damage figures for Lafayette Parish alone weren't in the sources used here; the 2016 flood figures above are statewide. Full guide: [Flood Zones & Insurance](#) →

PART 2

The Louisiana Homestead Exemption

The homestead exemption is one of the simplest, most valuable things a new Lafayette Parish homeowner can file for — and one of the easiest to forget. It exempts the first \$7,500 of a home's assessed value — equivalent to \$75,000 of market value — from property taxation, for owner-occupied primary residences ([Lafayette Parish Assessor](#)). It's governed by Louisiana Constitution Article VII, Section 20 ([Louisiana Legislature](#)). Louisiana residential property is assessed at 10% of fair market value, which is why \$75,000 of market value equals \$7,500 of assessed value ([Louisiana Law Help](#)).

\$75,000

Market value exempted from property tax

\$7,500

Assessed value exempted (10% assessment ratio)

Dec 31

Filing deadline for the year you acquire

Actual dollar savings depend on your specific millage rate — the Lafayette Parish Assessor's online estimator can show your exact figure ([Lafayette Parish Assessor estimator](#)).

Who qualifies

Owner-occupied as your primary residence as of January 1 of the tax year; only one exemption is allowed per person or household ([Louisiana Legislature](#)).

What to bring

Proof of ownership (deed or act of sale) and a valid Louisiana driver's license or state ID, taken to the assessor's office ([Louisiana Law Help](#)).

The deadline

File by December 31 of the year you acquire the property to get the exemption for that tax year ([source](#)). Miss it and you'll likely wait a year.

Where to go

Lafayette Parish Assessor's office, 213 West Vermilion Street, Lafayette, LA 70501. (337) 291-7080 ([Lafayette Parish Assessor](#)).

It's permanent — mostly. Once filed, the exemption does not require annual reapplication as long as you continue to own and occupy the home ([Lafayette Parish Assessor](#)). Some parishes ask for periodic occupancy confirmation — confirm current Lafayette Parish practice with the assessor's office directly. The exemption applies to parish and state ad valorem taxes but not municipal (city) taxes, except in specific circumstances such as certain school taxes ([Louisiana Legislature](#)).

Extra exemptions for veterans, seniors & disabled homeowners

Disabled veterans 50–69%

An additional \$2,500 of assessed value exemption on top of the standard exemption ([LA Dept. of Veterans Affairs](#)).

Disabled veterans 70–99%

An additional \$4,500 of assessed value exemption ([LA Dept. of Veterans Affairs](#)).

Disabled veterans 100%

Exempt from all ad valorem taxation except certain municipal assessments ([LA Dept. of Veterans Affairs](#)).

Seniors 65+ & permanently disabled

May apply for a Special Assessment Level "freeze" that locks assessed value if income requirements are met; Lafayette Parish sets the threshold at \$100,000 or less AGI ([Lafayette Parish Assessor](#)).

The freeze isn't a tax-rate freeze. The senior/disability freeze locks your assessed value, not the millage rate — your bill can still rise if taxing bodies raise their millage ([Jefferson Parish Assessor](#)). Income thresholds change year to year, so confirm the current figure with the Lafayette Parish Assessor before applying (*confirm with a professional*).

Full guide: [The Louisiana Homestead Exemption](#) →

PART 3

How Closing Works in Louisiana (the Act of Sale)

If you've bought a home anywhere else in the U.S., Louisiana's closing process will feel unfamiliar. Louisiana is the only U.S. state that operates under a civil law system, derived from the Napoleonic Code and French and Spanish colonial law, rather than English common law ([Quill Title & Closing](#)). Instead of an escrow-held closing, property transfers happen through an **act of sale** — a formal, notarized document that transfers ownership under Civil Code Article 1833, executed before a notary public and two witnesses, signed by each party, each witness, and the notary ([Justia](#); [NOLA Title Authority](#)).

Either an attorney-notary or a non-attorney notary can conduct the act of sale — but for title insurance purposes, an attorney must still examine the title and issue a title opinion even when a non-attorney notary handles the signing ([Quill Title & Closing](#)).

From offer to act of sale: the general timeline (30–60 days)

1. Purchase agreement signed

REALTOR® members statewide typically use the Louisiana Association of REALTORS standard residential purchase agreement ([LAR](#)).

2. Earnest money deposited

Typically within 24 hours of contract ratification ([Quill Title & Closing](#)).

3. Attorney title examination

Typically 14–30 days after the purchase agreement — surfaces liens or ownership issues before closing ([Quill Title & Closing](#)).

4. Act of sale executed

Buyer, seller, two witnesses and the notary sign, transferring ownership under Article 1833 ([Justia](#)).

5. Act of sale recorded

The notary records with the parish Clerk of Court within 15 days outside Orleans Parish, or 48 hours inside Orleans Parish ([Louisiana Legislature](#)).

6. Transfer is final

Once recorded, the transfer is effective against third parties ([Quill Title & Closing](#)).

Earnest money works differently here

Under Louisiana Civil Code Article 2624, if a seller recedes (backs out) without a contractual cause, the seller must return the buyer's earnest money *plus an equal amount* — the "double-return" rule ([Quill Title & Closing](#)). Ask Carrie to walk through your specific purchase agreement's terms, and confirm anything contract-specific with your closing attorney or notary.

Buyer closing costs

Buyers typically pay 2%–5% of the purchase price ([Southern Title](#)).

Seller closing costs

Average seller closing costs run around 3.15% of the purchase price ([Clever Real Estate](#)).

Title insurance

Not required for buyers but highly recommended; lenders always require a mortgagee policy, so if you finance, some form is part of the deal ([Crescent Title](#)).

Recording is local

Louisiana has 64 parishes, each with its own Clerk of Court, fees and turnaround times ([Quill Title & Closing](#)).

Married buyers: community property matters

CONFIRM WITH A PROFESSIONAL

Louisiana presumes property owned by a married person is community property, with exceptions for gifts, inheritances, and property acquired before marriage; both spouses generally must concur in the sale, mortgage, or lease of community real estate ([Louisiana Law Help](#)). How you hold title affects the paperwork from day one — raise it with your closing attorney or notary early. This is general information, not legal advice for your situation.

Cost figures are broad benchmarks, not itemized quotes — ask your title professional for an estimate (confirm with a professional). Full guide: [How Closing Works in Louisiana](#) →

PART 4

Zero-Down USDA Loans Around Acadiana

If you're house-hunting near Youngsville, Scott, Maurice or Carencro, a USDA loan can mean buying with no down payment at all — but eligibility is tied to the exact address, not the town name. The USDA Section 502 Guaranteed Loan Program provides 100% financing with no down payment for eligible rural homebuyers; USDA gives participating lenders a 90% loan note guarantee, the loans are 30-year fixed-rate, and reasonable closing costs can sometimes be financed in ([USDA Rural Development](#)).

\$0

Down payment required

115%

Max household income vs. area median

\$119,850

2026 income limit, 1–4 person household

\$158,250

2026 income limit, 5–8+ person household

Applicants generally can't exceed 115% of the area's median household income ([USDA Rural Development](#)). For context, Lafayette Parish's median household income is \$67,451 (2020–2024 Census data, [U.S. Census Bureau](#)). As of 2026, published USDA income limits allow households of 1–4 up to \$119,850 and 5–8+ up to \$158,250 ([Neighbors Bank](#)). The **Guaranteed** program doesn't apply a fixed area loan limit or maximum sale price — a lender qualifies you against income limits and standard debt-to-income underwriting instead.

Where it applies around Youngsville, Scott, Maurice & Carencro

USDA eligibility is address-specific. Roughly 42.3% of Lafayette Parish is ineligible for traditional USDA loans ([USDAProperties.com](#)), and core Lafayette city addresses generally don't qualify.

Youngsville

OFTEN ELIGIBLE

Higher eligibility likelihood per USDA property databases, though address-specific verification is still required.

Scott

OFTEN ELIGIBLE

Also flagged with higher eligibility likelihood in Lafayette Parish USDA data.

Maurice

100% ELIGIBLE PARISH

Vermilion Parish carries no geographic USDA restrictions, per official eligibility data (USDAProperties.com).

Carencro

OFTEN ELIGIBLE

Named among the surrounding areas commonly eligible outside Lafayette's ineligible core.

Always verify the exact address

CONFIRM PER ADDRESS

Property eligibility must be checked address-by-address on USDA's official eligibility map, not assumed from a town name ([USDA eligibility map](#)). USDA updated rural-area maps based on 2020 Census data ([USDA Rural Development notice](#)), so a fast-growing edge of Youngsville or Scott may have shifted. Some eligibility above is inferred from property-listing data (medium confidence) — ask Carrie or a lender to check the current map.

Credit

No federal minimum score, but many lenders look for 620+ ([USDA Rural Development](#)).

Debt-to-income

29%/41% standard for automatic approval; 32%/44% maximum allowed ([USDA DTI guidance](#)).

Occupancy

Owner-occupied primary residence only — no investment or rental use ([Neighbors Bank](#)).

Property types

Detached, attached, condo, PUD, modular and qualifying manufactured homes ([USDA Rural Development](#)).

*2026 income figures come from national USDA and lender sources, not a Lafayette-Parish-specific document — a lender should confirm the exact figure for your household size and address (confirm with a professional). A separate USDA **Direct** program (not covered here) does use a published area loan limit. Full guide: [Zero-Down USDA Loans](#) →*

PART 5

What Louisiana Sellers Must Disclose (and When)

Before you sign a listing agreement, it helps to know exactly what Louisiana law requires you to tell a buyer — and when. Louisiana sellers of residential property with 1–4 units must complete and deliver a Property Disclosure Document, as mandated by LSA-R.S. 9:3196–3200 ([La. R.S. 9:3196](#), via [Justia](#)). The form is not a warranty and is not part of any contract; the current official version is prescribed by the Louisiana Real Estate Commission ([LREC](#)). Real estate licensees cannot fill it out for you — the representations are the seller's, not the agent's ([Property Disclosure Document](#)).

Timing gives the buyer an out if you're late

The disclosure must be delivered no later than the time a buyer makes an offer ([srossie.com](#)). If it's delivered after the offer, the buyer may terminate or withdraw for up to 72 hours after receiving it — without penalty, with a full return of any deposit or earnest money ([Property Disclosure Document](#)).

A "known defect" is a condition actually known to the seller that (a) substantially hurts value, (b) significantly impairs future occupants' health or safety, or (c) if left unaddressed would significantly shorten the property's expected normal life ([Justia](#)). Since January 1, 2018, the form allows only YES or NK (No Knowledge) on each item — the old NO option was removed to stop blanket "no defects" answers ([Steeg Law](#)). Complete it in good faith as of the date you sign, and promptly correct it if something changes before closing ([srossie.com](#)).

What the form asks about

Structure & systems

Structures and additions, roof age, foundation repairs, plumbing, gas, sewerage, electrical, HVAC and appliances.

Pests & hazards

Termites and wood-destroying insects, lead-based paint (required for pre-1978 homes), and methamphetamine labs.

History & land

Land and servitudes, property damage history, and flood history and flood insurance.

Legal & community

Zoning and restrictive covenants, plus HOA, COA, or POA information.

If your property has flood history, disclose known flood claims and provide flood insurance declarations, elevation certificates and FEMA documentation if you have them (srossie.com). For homes built before 1978, provide the EPA/HUD lead-based paint pamphlet and complete the lead-based paint addendum ([Property Disclosure Document](#)).

You can't skip it by selling "as-is" **CONFIRM WITH A PROFESSIONAL**

An "as-is" clause doesn't erase the requirement. Willful misrepresentation or fraud on the form can still expose a seller to fraud and redhibition claims — Louisiana's doctrine letting a buyer pursue latent defects that existed at sale, potentially resulting in rescission, price reduction, recovery of expenses, and attorney's fees if the seller knowingly concealed the defect (srossie.com). But sellers aren't automatically liable for good-faith errors based on their best information, knowledge and belief ([Property Disclosure Document](#)). Some transfers are exempt (court-ordered, post-foreclosure, certain fiduciary, never-occupied new construction, between co-owners or to a spouse/blood relative, and more) — confirm exemption with a real estate attorney before assuming.

Exact damages for willful misrepresentation, how a "No Knowledge" answer is treated if a defect later surfaces, and the precise redhibition statute-of-limitations under Civil Code Article 2534 are questions for a real estate attorney (confirm with a professional). Full guide: [What Louisiana Sellers Must Disclose](#) →

PART 6

Which Acadiana Town Fits You? — a Comparison

Six Acadiana towns, six different price points. These figures aren't all the same measure — some are median closed-sale prices, others are Zillow's estimated average value, and one is a median asking (listing) price. Each cell is labeled with its measure, source and as-of date. For reference, Lafayette itself has a median sale price of \$240,606 ([Redfin](#), May–June 2026), down 2.7% year-over-year.

Home price measure, growth trend and school district by Acadiana town, as sourced and dated in each cell

Town	Price (measure, source, as of)	Trend	School district
Youngsville	\$314,812 — median sale price (Redfin , June 2026)	Population up 300% over three decades (KATC)	Lafayette Parish School System (LPSS)
Broussard	\$282,154 — average value (Zillow Zestimate) (Zillow , mid-2026)	Up 3.8% over past year (Zillow)	Lafayette Parish School System (LPSS)
Milton	\$313,500 — median listing (asking) price (Realtor.com , mid-2026)	Small, established community (2,590 residents, NeighborhoodScout)	Lafayette Parish School System (LPSS)
Scott	\$247,084 — median sale price (Redfin , May 2026)	Up 5.5% year-over-year (Redfin)	Lafayette Parish School System (LPSS)
Maurice	\$252,357 — average value (Zillow Zestimate) (Zillow , mid-2026)	Up 3.0% year-over-year (Zillow)	Vermilion Parish — Vermilion Parish School Board; zoning near the parish line can vary by address (VPSB)

Town	Price (measure, source, as of)	Trend	School district
Carencro	\$222,455 — median sale price (Redfin , May 2026)	Up 6.8% year-over-year (Redfin)	Lafayette Parish School System (LPSS)

Broussard and Maurice figures are Zillow's estimated average value, not a median closed-sale price; Milton's is a median listing (asking) price. Five of the six — Youngsville, Broussard, Milton, Scott and Carencro — are in the Lafayette Parish School System, which operates 44 school sites (LPSS). Maurice sits in Vermilion Parish (VPSB). School zoning can change — confirm your specific address with LPSS or VPSB directly.

If one thing matters most

Lowest price point

Carencro has the lowest median in this group at \$222,455, up 6.8% year-over-year; Scott is close behind at \$247,084 ([Redfin](#)).

Growth & new construction

Youngsville's population has grown 300% over three decades, and its Sports Complex draws roughly 1 million visitors a year ([KATC](#)).

Dining & shopping close by

Broussard features local Cajun cuisine restaurants and shopping centers, with a home value up 3.8% over the past year ([Jessica Broussard](#); [Zillow](#)).

Small & established

Milton is a community of 2,590 residents, mostly owner-occupied single-family homes ([NeighborhoodScout](#)).

For school ratings and crime data, review official sources yourself (LPSS, VPSB, NeighborhoodScout) and draw your own conclusions. Exact commute times weren't available from a sourced dataset — confirm with Carrie. Full guide: [Which Town Fits You?](#) →

PART 7

Work With Carrie

Carrie Billeaud is a Realtor with eXp Realty serving Lafayette and the greater Acadiana communities — Youngsville, Broussard, Carencro, Scott, Maurice and Milton. Whether you're buying your first home, relocating from an escrow state, or preparing to list, she walks each step personally: pulling flood zones and USDA eligibility before you tour, explaining the act-of-sale process so nothing at the notary's table is a surprise, and reviewing the Property Disclosure Document line by line before it reaches a buyer.

Buying

Straight answers on pre-approval, offers, flood and USDA checks, and closing — built for first-time and relocating buyers.

Selling

Pricing strategy, disclosure compliance, and a clear plan to get your Acadiana home in front of the right buyers.

After closing

Filing your homestead exemption before the December 31 deadline is part of the after-closing checklist, not an afterthought.

Contact Carrie Billeaud, Realtor · eXp Realty · Lafayette, Louisiana · 337-258-5379. *Buyer-agent compensation depends on the listing, the offer terms, and your buyer-agency agreement; Carrie will walk through exactly what applies before you tour homes.*

Before you rely on any of this **NOT LEGAL, TAX, LENDING OR INSURANCE ADVICE**

This compiled guide is informational only. Flood maps, tax rules, program terms, disclosure requirements and market figures all change over time. Always verify current details for your specific situation with the relevant licensed professional — FEMA and a licensed insurance agent, the Lafayette Parish Assessor, a licensed Louisiana attorney or notary, a USDA-approved lender, and the appropriate school board — before making a decision.

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